*Supporting narrated video (NV) demonstrations, high-speed video (HSV) clips, technical proofs (TP), and all past articles are available online at **drdavepoolinfo.com**. Reference numbers used in the articles help you locate the resources on the website.*

When hitting a pool shot, what are your eyes focused on during the final forward stroke? Do you focus on the cue ball (CB) last, or the object ball (OB) last? A recent video on this topic, with Jayson Shaw explaining his eye pattern, was widely circulated on social media. I decided it was important to help put Jayson's video in perspective, hence this article, which summarizes important points from online video **NV L.81** dealing with eye pattern "best practices."

Image 1 Controversial Jayson Shaw eye pattern video

Unlike most players, Jayson focusses on the CB during his final stroke. He states: "What's the point in looking at the OB?" Well, my video and the remainder of this article answer this question. He also stated in the video: "I think a lot of people actually look at the OB as their last ball." That is most certainly correct, especially with many other top players.

Since Jayson is one of the most accurate shooters in the world, hence his nickname "Eagle Eye," many people took notice of the video and thought they should start doing what he does. Well, before you do this, please consider everything below.

Here's a summary of eye pattern "best practices" recommended by most top instructors and followed by most top players:

1. Focus at the OB while getting down into your stance (see **Image 2a**) and look at the CB as the tip gets close.

2. Look back and forth between the CB and OB with the cue still to carefully verify tip position and the cue's alignment with the desired line of aim.

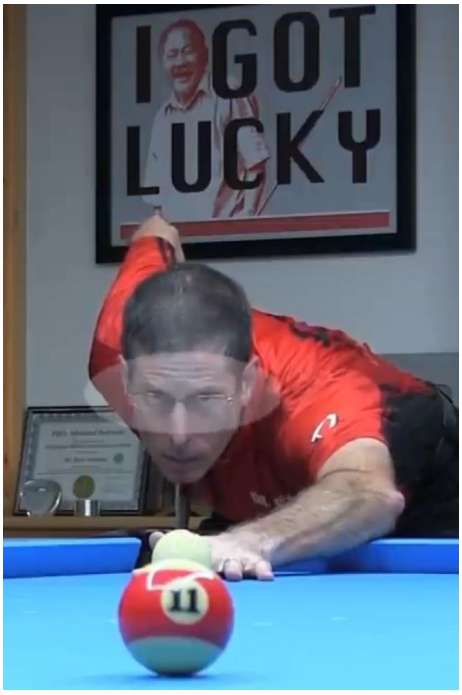
3. Look at the CB during any warm-up strokes. Or alternatively, look at the CB during forward strokes and the OB during backstrokes.

4. Stop at the CB and do one more tip and cue alignment check, again with the cue still.

5. Lock your focus on the OB before the final stroke (see **Image 2b**). Or, alternatively, if you have a long pause at the end of your backstroke, lock the focus during the pause.

6. Keep your focus along the shot line during and after the final stroke, resisting the urge to turn your head or get up to see where the OB is going.

a) **OB focus during the drop**



b) OB focus during the final stroke

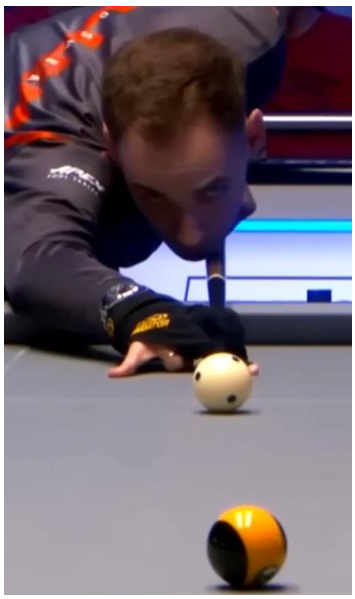
Image 2 Eye pattern "best practices"

So how can Jayson be so accurate if he is not using the recommended eye pattern "best practices?" Well, once you are lined up properly, it is not actually critical what you focus on as long as your focus is locked, keep your head and body still during the stroke, and use "best practices" stroke mechanics. You could even close your eyes before the final stroke (ala Michael Jordan showing off shooting blind free throws) and still get good results; although, nobody in their right mind would do such a thing in an important pool match.

With enough practice over many dedicated years of consistent repetition, you can learn to master any technique (like Jayson has). However, there are slight advantages to OB focus for most people, as described below. BTW, if you want to improve your stroke mechanics, so you can have the desired stillness, accuracy, and consistency with fewer years of dedicated practice, see the stroke "best practices" resource page at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

To help show that many players focus on the OB last, I decided to look at players who made it to the final rounds in the recent European Open, which included many of the world's top pros. Videos of these matches (or highlights) are available on YouTube. With some of the players, it was difficult to tell where their focus was with the camera views available. Although, the eyebrows are often a dead giveaway, even when the eye's aren't clearly visible. In **Image 3a**, Szewczyk's has OB focus. In the video, his eyebrows obviously shift from the CB to the OB before the final forward stroke. Josh Filler is currently the best player in the world, and he clearly has OB focus (with raised eyebrows) during his final stroke (see **Image 3b**). Shane VanBoening, one of the greatest players of all time and America's current best, definitely follows eye pattern "best practices." He has intense locked focus on the OB before and during the entire final stroke (see **Image 3c**).

a) Szewczyk



b) Filler

c) VanBoening

Image 3 Top Pro OB Focus

Of the nine players in the matches available on YouTube who made it to the final rounds of the European Open, six of the nine players had clear OB focus, and only one (Jayson Shaw) had clear CB focus. For the other two players, the focus was not clear in the video footage available. It is no surprise that Filler and VanBoening, two of the current best players who went deep in the tournament, exhibit what is widely considered eye pattern "best practices."

Below are the reasons why most top players in all cue sports focus on the OB just before and during the final stroke. Again, OB focus does not offer a large advantage, but it is recommended:

1. The distant focus helps you maintain the desired aim since you can clearly see what is called the aiming "shot picture."

2. The distant focus helps you deliver the cue more straight toward your target. This is also the case in other sports like with free throws in basketball (with focus on the rim), bowling (with focus on the arrows down the lane), baseball pitching (with focus on the target over the plate), horseshoes (with focus on the stake), and darts (with focus on the target). In all these examples, the final focused gaze is at the distant target. This helps maintain straight aim and helps ensure straighter implement delivery in the target direction. Although, one must be careful with sports analogies since pool is unique in many ways. For more information, see the last section of the eye pattern "best practices" resource page at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***, which discusses racquet sports, batting sports, and golf as poor eye pattern analogies to pool.

3. Focus on the OB helps ensure you keep your head and body still during and after the stroke, instead of looking up from CB focus to see where the CB is heading.

4. With OB focus, you can better diagnose and learn from each shot since you can immediately and more clearly see the direction the CB heads and where it hits the OB, without needing to move your eyes or head during the shot.

One exception to focusing on the OB last is with long, highly-elevated-cue shots, the topic of a recent video I did covering this important technique (see **NV L.79**). With these shots, CB focus during the final stroke is often more effective for most players since even a tiny trace of unintentional sidespin can cause a miss.

Snooker arguably requires some of the best shot-making of any cue sport. Neil Robertson, in a guest appearance on Stephen Hendry's YouTube Channel (see **Image 5**), offered some interesting perspectives and

useful tips. Both Hendry and Robertson are considered among the best to have ever played the sport, and even they don't totally agree on which eye pattern is best.

Image 5 Snooker greats Stephen Hendry and Neil Robertson

Be sure to check out online video **NV L.81** if you want to learn more and see demonstrations of everything above. And if you still need convincing that focusing on the OB during the stroke offers slight advantages, check out the entire eye pattern "best practices" resource page at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Good luck with your game,
Dr. Dave

normal video

NV L.81 – EYE PATTERN "Best Practices" … Cue Ball or Object Ball Focus Last?
NV L.79 – How to Be More Accurate With Jacked-Up or Elevated-Cue Shots

PS:

- I know other authors and I tend to use lots of terminology, and I know not all readers are totally familiar with these terms. If you ever come across a word or phrase you do not fully understand, please refer to the online glossary at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Dr. Dave is a PBIA Master Instructor, Dean of the Billiard University, and author of the book: The Illustrated Principles of Pool and Billiards and numerous instructional DVD series, all available at: ***DrDaveBilliards.com***.